



The Grand Canyon

A vast gorge cut by the Colorado River, the Grand Canyon holds a record of 1.7 billion years of Earth history in its walls

One of North America's most iconic landscapes, the Grand Canyon is a spectacular valley carved into the Colorado Plateau by the Colorado River over millions of years. Renowned for its dramatic rock formations, precipitous cliffs, and striking coloration, the canyon is named for its impressive scale. Averaging 4,000 ft (1,220 m) deep for its entire length of 277 miles (446 km), it drops 6,000 ft (1,830 m) below the rim at its deepest and reaches 18 miles (29 km) across at its widest.

A record in the walls

An extraordinary demonstration of the powerful forces of erosion, the Grand Canyon is one of Earth's best-studied geological features. The layers of rock exposed on its walls present a remarkable record of geological history reaching back almost 2 billion years, although the canyon itself is much younger.



▷ CLIFFS AT TUWEEP

Sunlight pierces the early morning fog, illuminating the sheer face of the canyon wall and revealing the Colorado River far below.

◁ GAINING TRACTION

Forked hooves that spread apart to improve grip enable the desert bighorn sheep to move freely on steep slopes. It can survive for long periods without drinking water.

In some places, **the canyon** is more than **1 mile (1.8 km) deep**

THE SHAPE OF THE CANYON

The Grand Canyon extends from Lees Ferry in the east to Grand Wash Cliffs in the west. As well as the main river channel, there are hundreds of miles of tributaries contained within side canyons. The canyon's North Rim is about 980 ft (300 m) higher than the South Rim as the plateau slopes downward from north to south.

